

How bad are AI Overviews for the environment?

Posted by u/Due_Recognition_3890 • 0 points • 3 comments

I've had a lot of anxiety over using Google lately, I feel guilty Googling anything whenever I forget to put "-ai" at the end of my search, or SwiftKey automatically puts a space in there to negate the minus effect. I've watched all these videos saying generating an AI response is the equivalent of all these bottles of water, and I can't help but contemplate how much of a disaster this is given that everyone uses Google, and most people aren't aware of removing AI from your searches.

Comments

u/AgentElman • 4 points • 2025-10-26 21:28 UTC

Those videos are lying to you. They are both making up the numbers, and adding in all of the work it took to train the AI.

It would be like saying using a kitchen knife is terrible for the environment because it uses all of the coal used to make all of the steel ever made.

The AI Overview takes almost no resources.

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-10-26 21:35 UTC

[Here's more details.](<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about>)
Another thing they often use is people just not having an idea of how much a certain amount of electricity or water actually is. The amount of water used in food is orders of magnitude more, and people often use enough electricity that they're worried about the price.

Also, I'd imagine the AI overview uses a particularly small and low-cost model, since all it has to do is summarize the results the search already found.

u/generic_redditor_71 • 4 points • 2025-10-26 21:09 UTC

Just think about it for a second. If it were significantly more resource-intensive than the rest of the search operation then Google couldn't afford to just add it to every search for free.